

Print Magazine's Attributes and Relevancy in the Lens of Filipino K-pop fans in Metro Manila

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Abstract— Numerous studies have been carried out to determine how K-pop fans decide to purchase products associated with their idol. However, as has been noted, the rise in sales and demand for print magazines with K-pop idols on the cover has yet to be explained. This study employed a mixed-methods approach to analyze and comprehend what characteristics K-pop fans look for in print magazines and how the Korean wave and their fandom influence their decision to purchase a K-pop magazine or not. The study used 385 K-pop fans as respondents using a purposive sampling technique because the researchers believed that these groups have their own unique decisions and experiences that will influence how they will purchase a specific product. The preferences of Filipino K-pop fans in Metro Manila on the attributes of the print magazine, their behavior as consumers, and its relevance in this digital age are the focus of this research study.

Keywords— *K-pop, Magazine Attributes, Filipino fans, qualitative research*

I. INTRODUCTION

The beautiful content division, eye-catching packaging, variety, impressive design, and quality paper did not survive the inevitable change brought about by technological advancement. Despite the growing influence of social media, revenues in print media declined, but an empirical study revealed that digital magazines saved the print media industry. According to the International Magazine Publishers Association (MPA), advertisement revenue in tablet magazines increased by 16% in 2013, while print media only increased by 0.1%. [1]. Moreover, a print magazine's only chance of surviving its life cycle is to adapt to its readers' changing needs, and to remain relevant, magazines must consider both their environments and their readers. As a result, when confronted with a new electronic challenge, the first of many in the coming decades, magazine publishers responded with vigor. Simply put, magazines have discovered that the key to their success is to be both necessary and sufficient [2].

According to a journal article titled Past, Present, and Future of Hallyu (Korean Wave), the roots of Hallyu had a significant impact not only on culture and economy but also on what Korea is now doing on a global stage [3]. In line with

that, the positive aspect of Hallyu is that the Korean government is not wasting any time in supporting the phenomenon that it is creating. According to the same study, social media has become the fastest way for K-pop to spread and is large enough to replace traditional print, aural, and visual media [4]. The fusion of print magazines and technology paved the way for the transition to digital sources and platforms. As a result, print magazine production has decreased [5].

Despite the fact that many studies have been conducted on how K-pop fans decide on purchasing products associated with their idol, there have been few studies on how K-pop fans decide whether to buy a physical copy of a magazine. This research study aims to determine what attributes of print magazines and the influence of their fandom to help them decide whether or not to buy a print magazine. Furthermore, it examines the relevance of physical copies in the digital age through the eyes of K-pop Filipino fans in Metro Manila. This study contributes to the Philippine magazine industry by determining the various perspectives of K-pop Filipino fans on purchasing a print magazine.

II. RELATED LITERATURE

A. Hallyu wave and K-pop merchandise

Korean pop music, or K-pop, as it is most commonly known, has become one of the most influential—or is now the biggest contributor—to distributing dynamic forms of pop culture in the global market scene with the help of social distribution networks. The record industry alone is not enough. Its profitability makes it impossible to solve the crises it faces. As the Korean music record market shrinks and left-right groups with the same genre and style debut, the Korean music industry has resorted to changing its business plan and structures [4]. Sadly, idol groups have to deal with having a short life cycle as artists. With this problem, this industry is set to make a profit as long as it can during a short period of time. Furthermore, the Korean entertainment industry places itself in a position to generate its topmost revenue in such a short period of time but still secure the target market (fandom) that will purchase the products and services that their idols are

included in. In addition, this method was borrowed from Japan's entertainment industry and called "one-source-multiuse." It was adopted by the Korean entertainment sector and given a distinctive twist by featuring the artist in various items known as idol goods or emphasizing the close relationship between idol stars and their fandoms. [6].

B. Magazine readers and structure

Magazine readers prefer to become involved with the magazines they read rather than being passive recipients of information. Attachment to a magazine brand is reported to frequently lead to imagined communities, in which readers believe they are part of a larger community of readers who all share a fondness for the publication [9]. However, no matter how it came from multiple authors that target different audiences, magazines are loaded with texts to analyze because of their presentation and rich meaning, which come with infinite challenges of interpretation and criticism [10]. Also, there's a whole other world inside the magazine, especially for its target audience, in terms of what it can offer: embracing every aspect of life, nurturing body and mind, teaching lifestyle, encouraging success at home, in the workplace, and in all kinds of relationships, and thus seemingly leading the way to a more fulfilled existence.

Learning how to design material in a way that draws readers in and generates a strong verbal-visual connection for the audience may be tough and exciting. Today's viewers demand amazing visual graphics and storytelling presented in a way that captures and holds their attention. Publications must feature intriguing story-telling imagery, instructive graphics, and well-chosen text to captivate readers [11].

The magazine medium, with its editorial voice and ability to establish communities, provides an excellent approach to transmit a coherent set of ideas. According to magazine research findings [12], the following are presumably the benefits of the magazine medium: (1) the capacity of magazines to draw audiences together via the building of communities around themes, and (2) the medium's distinctive style of approach.

Magazines also engage their readers with their content and usually advocate lifestyle changes. Specialized publications provide "calculated packages of meaning whose aim is to transform the reader into an imaginary subject," encouraging readers to identify with magazine visuals. In this direct communication, the editorial persona refers to the reader as "you," implying that the reader should act on the magazine's ideas, typically through lifestyle changes, as part of self-actualization [13].

The usage of the second person is prevalent in magazine material. There is evidence that magazine content has an effect on readers, but it is uncertain whether or not readers will respond to this encouragement. [14]. This study, which focuses mostly on Western women's body image and magazine exposure, indicates that magazine material has the ability to drastically and permanently affect audience perceptions [15].

A specific magazine's visual grammar is produced in the cultural environment in which the audience works as a result of interactions between the defined audience and magazine publishers throughout time. Magazine layout is a well-established commercial process that involves the

transformation of editorial material into visual communication and design activity. It seems to reason that in order for the information offered on a page to be useful to the audience, it must be interactive. The layout, contents, page margins, and magazine proportions all contribute to various parts of grammar [12].

C. Consumer Behavior

Studies show that consumers can better understand and predict the subject of purchases, as well as their frequency and motivations, through consumer behavior research [16]. On the other hand, facts and subjectively perceived value are the reasons why people keep buying a product, not its main function. But he also mentioned that a consumer doesn't give importance to a product's basic function; nowadays, what a product can do goes beyond its service limits [17].

However, other than focusing on personal qualities, there are no other relevant tasks to address in consumer behavior research. According to their research, the term "consumer" is more commonly used than "target customer," and the term "consumer behavior" is more accurate in this type of study. since of this way of thinking, it eventually became an issue since it needed the individual to comprehend additional roles as a decision-maker, buyer, and consumer [18].

III. METHOD

This study used a mixed-methods design to determine what attributes of K-pop print magazines influence the decision to purchase the magazine or not. It also looked at the relevance of physical magazine copies in the digital age through the eyes of Metro Manila-based Filipino K-pop fans. A mixed-method study was used because quantitative and qualitative data allowed the researchers to analyze the data and gain a comprehensive understanding of the research gap. The researchers used an online survey questionnaire with a Likert scale rating to elicit insights and experiences. This study surveyed 385 K-pop fans in Metro Manila, Philippines, both those who had previously purchased K-pop merchandise and those who had not. The participants agreed to remain anonymous throughout the study and signed consent forms.

IV. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

In Table 1, the idea of high fashion as the visual content of the K-pop-related magazine photoshoot gets the highest mean score with 4.35, suggesting that the majority of respondents strongly agree with it. This suggests that fashion has an influence on the contemporary K-pop business. While K-pop musicians sell their music to their fans, high fashion labels understand the capacity of the K-pop community to support their favorite artists. More and more artists, such as BTS and BLACKPINK, began to gain recognition not only in the music industry but also in the fashion world, with BLACKPINK members securing individual ambassadorships in CELINE, Dior, YSL, and Chanel, which eventually extended to male artists such as BTS in brands such as Louis Vuitton and Valentino [19].

K-pop idols have distinct fashion tastes that enable them to be identified by fans and develop their own personal brand. This vision was seen by luxury firms as a chance to sell and

develop their products, particularly in the Asian market [20]. Fans prefer to dress up like their favorites, therefore performances by prominent K-pop groups like BLACKPINK and BTS are frequently sold out straight away.

TABLE 1. THE VISUAL CONTENT OF K-POP MAGAZINE PHOTOSHOOT

Category	Mean	Standard Deviation	Interpretation
High fashion	4.35	0.945	Strongly Agree
Edgy	3.81	0.995	Agree
Classic	4.05	0.919	Strongly Agree
3D rendered	3.63	1.02	Agree

In Table 2, music has the highest mean (4.52), followed by fashion (4.42), indicating that the majority of respondents strongly agree on the two topics of the K-pop-related print magazine issue. Due of the nearly three-year-long outbreak, some newsstands were forced to close. According to their interview with The Guardian, they do not know if print publications would return in 2020. It must deliver more than it can in order to exist as a music magazine in 2020. Some magazines have turned to and adapted to internet publishing. After two (2) years, there was an upsurge in magazine sales and demand, particularly for those with a fashion or music focus. And, as seen by the statistics presented above, the majority of respondents responded to the music-themed magazine that encouraged them to buy it. By contemplating having K-pop musicians on their covers, this might assist improve the creation of music-themed magazine publications. [5]. Even though there is a lot of music magazine content available online, editors, publicists, and readers believe that print magazines still have something unique to offer [21].

TABLE 2. THE OVERALL THEME OF A K-POP MAGAZINE

Category	Mean	Standard Deviation	Interpretation
Fashion	4.42	0.960	Strongly agree
Music	4.52	0.927	Strongly agree
Health/Wellness	3.70	0.985	Agree
Lifestyle	3.96	0.999	Agree

The highest mean in Table 3 is 4.41, indicating that the majority of respondents strongly agree that artist's quotes entice K-pop fans to purchase K-pop-related print magazines, implying that they are very interested in it and that those quotes or messages have an impact on the fans. An artist's or idol's responsibility is to not only amuse their audience, but also to act as a role model for them [22]. Artists have a beneficial impact on their followers, motivating people to grow [23], be inspired, and live completely [24].

TABLE 3. THE COPYWRITING CONTENT OF A K-POP MAGAZINE

Category	Mean	Standard Deviation	Interpretation
Artist's quotes	4.41	0.934	Strongly agree
Magazine Issue	3.64	1.08	Agree
Artist's Interview	4.39	0.910	Strongly agree
Magazine Headline	4.19	0.969	Strongly Agree

Photocards have the highest mean in Table 4 with 4.60, indicating that the majority of respondents highly agree with the idea of photocards as inclusions or freebies included in K-pop print magazines and will strongly purchase the magazine. Collecting stuff, whether official or unauthorized, is one of the things that fans perform to demonstrate their love and support in the K-pop community because product is highly popular [25]. One of them is a photocard. It is a wallet-sized picture captured by a professional photographer during a photoshoot or a "selfie" of the K-pop artist.

TABLE 4. INCLUSIONS/FREEBIES IN K-POP MAGAZINE

Category	Mean	Standard Deviation	Interpretation
Photocards	4.60	0.930	Strongly agree
Posters	4.31	1.03	Strongly agree
Calendar	3.79	1.13	Agree
Stickers	4.08	1.10	Strongly agree

Finally, Korea has the highest mean among the others in Table 5, with 4.58, showing that the publication of K-pop magazines in Korea entices Filipino K-pop fans to purchase K-pop-related print magazines due to K-pop idol groups. [26]. The entire average, however, falls within the "agree" range, with a computed average value of 3.77. This suggests that Metro Manila-based Filipino K-pop respondents are unconcerned with where the K-pop-related magazine was published in the specified nations.

TABLE 5. ORIGIN OF PUBLICATION OF K-POP MAGAZINE

Category	Mean	Standard Deviation	Interpretation
Korea	4.58	0.910	Strongly agree
United States	3.51	1.07	Agree
China	3.07	1.01	Agree
Japan	3.93	1.09	Agree

These are the five (5) identified themes from the qualitative data collection in response to the question of how the fandom influences individuals to purchase a K-pop print magazine.

A. Support of Filipino K-pop fans

Part of the fan culture is to show your love and return the happiness they have given you by showing your support. Furthermore, being a K-pop fan means that you will support your idol by streaming their music, sharing their posts, and, in some cases, purchasing their merchandise. Fans' celebrity worship of K-pop idols has dramatically demonstrated that their intimate support for their K-pop idols matters when consuming K-pop merchandise. In K-pop culture, there is fierce competition, with many K-pop fandoms wanting their idols to sell the most albums, magazines, and other merchandise [27].

Participant 36 stated that "*K-pop fandom is all about supporting your favorite idol or group, and one way of supporting them is by buying their magazines and other merchandise. Although not buying their merchandise will not make you less of a fan, others show their support through this.*"

Participant 211 explains that *"if it is the K-Idols themselves they have a role in influencing fans to buy a magazine. Who wouldn't want to have a physical copy to support the artists they love and stan. Having any piece of evidence or merch shows how much you care and support the group or member alone. The K-pop fandom is a community so buying merch such as magazines can not only show support to the artist but a mutual bond among the K-pop community since it has the potential to bring about friendships or at the slightest talk about the magazine."*

As reiterated by Participant 51, *"K-pop fandom influences me to buy magazines whenever I see their posts on social media about their magazines. also, the competition between sales, because the fandom wants their favored idols to have the most album/magazine sold."*

B. Sense of intimacy to K-pop Idols

Fans can get to know their idols more personally through the content of magazines, which emphasizes the close relationship between idols and their fandoms. They learn about the story, insights, opinions, life lessons, and many other things that leave an impression on their heart and mind. As a result, satisfaction and motivation are created [6].

As supported by Participant 160, *"what influence[s] me is that you will be curious on what is inside the magazine. And their magazine will give you some piece of them (artist's information)."*

As reminisced by Participant 227, *"fangirling over the previews of those magazines! It was such a budol (charmed/convince you to buy) once you admire a group member who gets to become a magazine cover. Because of the intense fangirling and unconditional support for the group/member I stan, the K-Pop fandom can influence me in buying magazines because I also want to read and check the insides of that certain magazine. The preview photos are not enough to get to know my favorites more. I always appreciate reading and checking them through magazines."*

Aside from knowing the music of their idols, fans can get to know their idols more personally through this type of project. By emphasizing the close relationship between idol stars and their fandoms, or by featuring the artist in various items known as idol merchandise. This is where they learn about the story, insight, opinion, life lesson, and many other things that leave an impression on their heart and mind. As a result of the impact of their idols' interviews in the magazine, satisfaction and motivation were created. Featuring the artist in a variety of idol merchandise items or emphasizing the close relationship between idol stars and their fandoms [6].

Participant 275 stated that *"it is not just the fandom that influences me in buying magazines, it is the idols themselves. I love how they see the world in different view, all in positive views. They always find something beautiful to say no matter how difficult, how negative, how cruel the world is to them. The fandom, I like sharing thoughts with my fellow K-pop fans. I always ask if what do they think of this and that and*

we'll compare and contrast, share, learn, and analyze our different perspectives. It also makes me happy having to collect different magazines featuring my idols and the idea of my friends (other K-pop fans) having to do the same thing."

Participant 37 mentioned that *"it influences me in a way that I want to get to know the group beyond their music. Being able to hear their opinions and thoughts on certain topics, issues or questions that personally correlate to them is something interesting to me."*

As supported by Participant 213, *"in a way of I am learning something about them and more on I also gain life lessons from them that's why I also invest in their magazines."*

C. Marketing strategies

Cups, towels, and souvenirs are just a few examples of idol's merchandise that depict K-pop idols, or something related to them. Idol merchandise became a thing to grant and satisfy fandom desires [28]. One of the factors that greatly influences fans is K-pop's marketing strategy. They effectively advertise and market their products. Sales of products bearing the names and faces of K-pop idols increased. It grew by an average of 190.5%. This demonstrates the marketability of K-pop [29].

Participant 25 recalls that *"they advertise the magazines in a way that it encourages someone like me (who is very frugal) to buy a magazine from my favorite K-pop idol."*

Pricing is one of the factors that consumers consider before purchasing a product. Pricing has a significant impact on a consumer's purchasing behavior. While there are several factors mentioned that influence the price of the product, such as branding and brand loyalty. It explained various thresholds that cause product prices or consumer budget capabilities to rise or fall. Several respondents mentioned that pricing, discounts, and magazine inclusions are some of the factors they consider before purchasing a magazine. They look at and consider these factors when deciding whether to buy a magazine. Some of the responses may be influenced by the magazine's contents, but there are others choose not to buy because of their economic situation [32].

Participant 212 mentioned that *"personally, they will influence you in the inclusion of the magazines itself. Some magazine offers they will have posters, postcard, and limited edition of photocards of the said artist or group. And it will catch your attention or the attention of the consumer to buy the magazine."*

Participant 276 stated that *"K-pop fandom influence me to buy magazines of the group we stan by showing what the inclusions of the magazines, in this way I was able to think whether it is worthy of my money."*

Every magazine cover is unique, and as a result, companies, artists, and fans regard this as a collectible. Some respondents pointed out that not every section of their idol's magazine can be viewed online. As a result, those who purchased it have the so-called limited edition.

As noted by Participant 217, “when there are limited freebies, the magazine is a special edition, or when the specific artist that you stan are on the cover page.”

This was supported by Participant 63 by stating that “the fandom influences me to buy magazines because of the exclusive content that can only be accessed through the said material.”

D. Personal Satisfaction of Filipino K-pop fans

K-pop fans have found a source of comfort, happiness, and positivity, as well as nostalgic importance. Psychological elements such as desire for buying, how it is regarded, skills and knowledge, where one is positioned, personality, and lifestyle are all factors that make people buy a magazine. Perception is also important [32].

Participant 129 notes that “it is my personal choice to buy magazines especially if it features my fav idol/groups” & “I don’t normally buy a lot of magazines even if it’s local or international (Korean) magazines, but if my favorite artists is on the cover and a lot of fans put a lot of attention to the magazine, then it is making me have the urge to buy magazine too.”

As reiterated by Participant 379, “if the magazines contain the faces and other related things with the groups that I stan, I will be 100% interested because all things that are related to them have sparks for me.”

E. Relevancy of physical magazines in digital age

Some respondents believe that having a print magazine is no longer relevant in this digital age. A few of them are simply not interested in magazines. Another reason is the widespread use of the internet, as technically, photos are uploaded to sites like Instagram and Twitter, where fans can easily save them. However, based on the data gathered, 87.3% of the 385 respondents said that having a print magazine is still very relevant in this digital era. Individually, they provide a fantastic explanation of the importance of it.

Many of them stated that having a physical copy of a magazine gives them a different kind of feelings. Having it in your hand feels more intimate and provides a stronger connection than viewing it on a screen. Aside from that, you won’t be interrupted while reading it because there are no advertisements that will pop up. Many people also stated that a print magazine can be used to design your room or a shop where other people can maximize its use.

Just as Participant 35 stated, “aside from the fact that the digital age makes consumption better and eco-friendly, by personal preferences, printed ones make the experience and interaction interesting and special.”

When it comes to having a print magazine, most participants responded that they consider them collectibles, investments, and a part of their to-do list, especially because publications are generally uncommon and restricted in

production. Overall, the continued production of print magazines is extremely sensible in this age of technology due to the significance of physical copies of the magazine. Although it is not for everyone, magazines have their own market to target where their work and creativity may still be enjoyed by the general audience. Husni and Main [2] strongly support this finding, arguing that the only way for a magazine to survive the life cycle is to adapt to its readers' changing needs, which we can connect to the data and findings we gathered above about how these K-pop-related magazines sell themselves to their target market, which is K-pop fans.

V. CONCLUSION

The researchers conducted an online survey to reach out to K-pop enthusiasts in Metro Manila, Philippines, for this study. Most respondents picked high fashion as the subject of a content photoshoot, music as the theme of a magazine issue, artist quotations as copywriting content, photocards as inclusions, and Korea as the preferred magazine publication. It also assists in the investigation and identification of consumer behavior-influencing characteristics such as fan support, fandom influence, personal interests, and emotional pleasure. Even if the magazine business has a fixed structure and philosophy on how a magazine should be built, there are still methods to enhance and step up the game while producing a print magazine. The researchers were able to evaluate the attributes that K-pop fans desired in print magazines, how they made purchase decisions, and the usefulness of print publications in this digital age based on the data obtained.

However, this study's findings may refute Husni and Main's [2] assertion that new media's first threat to print has been the greatest threat to publishing environments. This must be true in some ways about what digital content can offer, but this article backs up Fung's [9] claim that magazine readers prefer to actively engage with the publications they read rather than being passive consumers of information. According to Siriyuvusak and Hyunjoon [32], magazine brand loyalty frequently leads to constructed communities in which readers think they are part of a broader group of individuals who all appreciate the magazine. The data obtained indicates the new opportunities for print magazines to remain relevant in this digital age while continuing to produce print publications.

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